

Module 2: Philosophies of Education

EDUC 219 - Howard University

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1 Module overview

This module introduces historical traditions and contemporary discourses in philosophies of education. We will examine how philosophical ideas shape beliefs about the purposes of education, the role of schools in democratic society, the relationships among knowledge, learning, teaching, and citizenship, and the distribution of educational opportunity.

The module also asks students to consider how philosophical commitments relate to diversity, equal access, social justice, and professional identity. As students develop their personal philosophies of education, they will connect course ideas to historical evidence, lived experiences, and questions about the responsibilities of schools and educational professionals.

2 Guiding questions

- What is a philosophy of education?
- What purposes should education and schools serve in a democratic society?
- How have major philosophical traditions shaped American educational thought and practice?
- How do different philosophies understand knowledge, learning, authority, curriculum, and citizenship?
- How should philosophies of education respond to diversity, unequal opportunity, power, and social justice?
- How can historical inquiry and course evidence inform an individual philosophy of education?

3 Key concepts

- Philosophy of education
- Democratic education
- Educational aims and purposes
- Knowledge and curriculum
- Authority and freedom
- Equality, equity, and access
- Diversity and multiculturalism
- Social justice
- Professional identity and agency

4 Readings and activities

- Givens (2021), Chapter 1
- Additional readings and media on Canvas
- Philosophy of education thematic analysis
- Drafting and revising the individual philosophy of education statement
- Excursion 1, to be determined as a group

Assignment connection

The updated philosophy of education statement is due Sunday, September 13. Your final philosophy of education is an individual assignment and is not a philosophy of teaching. It should explain your developing understanding of the purposes, values, and responsibilities of education.